

This unhappy result was due to three causes. In the *first* place, most of the pupils of the secondary schools of those days belonged to the educationally advanced classes of society whose main object was to obtain employment under Government because it secured, at one stroke, a black-coated profession, a status in society, and economic improvement. They flocked to the secondary schools, not with a view to being trained for the *various stations in life*—but with the definite objective of passing the Matriculation which, in those days, opened the door to service under Government. To the more ambitious of these, the passing of the Matriculation meant an entrance to the University from where they could get into higher and more lucrative posts under Government. Hence these classes of society came to attach an exaggerated importance to the Matriculation examination and to a proficiency in English. This demand for the Matriculation certificate was bound to be reflected in the work of secondary schools—all the more so because the bulk of secondary schools came, in the course of time, to be managed by the educationally advanced classes themselves. *Secondly*, Government itself had not taken any steps to provide vocational education in secondary schools. In those days, the schools conducted by Government were considered to be *model* institutions and usually set the standard for private entrepreneurs to follow; and as Government schools made no provision for vocational courses, it was hardly to be wondered if private schools did not do so. *Thirdly*, most of the newer schools that came into existence did not have adequate financial resources at the start, and hence they usually confined their work to the course of liberal education leading to the Matriculation because it required the least equipment and expenditure. One need not, therefore, be surprised if the average secondary school of 1882 meant merely a place for preparing candidates for the Matriculation examination.

The Indian Education Commission, therefore, gave considerable attention to the provision of vocational courses at the upper secondary stage with a view to preparing pupils for various walks of life. It recommended a bifurcation of the secondary course and said:

We, therefore, recommend that in the upper classes of high

schools there be two divisions; one leading to the Entrance examination of the Universities, the other of a more practical character, intended to fit youths for commercial or non-literary pursuits. (p. 221)

This recommendation was accepted and alternative examinations came to be organised in every province. But the experience was not encouraging. Taking India as a whole, we find that in 1901-2, no less than 23,000 candidates appeared for the Matriculation examination; but the total number of candidates appearing for all the other alternative examinations was only about 2,000 of which about 1,200 belonged to Bombay Province (where many candidates took both the examinations). It is quite evident, therefore, that the alternative courses did not become popular and that the Matriculation examination dominated the field of secondary education almost as exclusively in 1902 as it did in 1882.

In 1902, therefore, the system of secondary education in India presented a strange mixture of good and evil. On the one hand, there had been considerable expansion—particularly of Indian enterprise. On the other hand, there was a good deal of inefficiency and there were serious defects such as the lack of vocational education and the use of English as a medium of instruction. The similarity between this picture and that of collegiate education in 1901-2 is too close to need comments and led to precisely similar controversies in the early years of the twentieth century. The history of these later developments, however, will be dealt with in Chapter VII.

Effects of the New Education (1854-1902): We have so far briefly traced the history of the development of university and secondary education in India between 1855 and 1902. The most distinctive achievement of the British educationists in India was the creation of this new system of education whose object was to spread Western literature and science and which adopted English as a medium of instruction at all stages except the lower secondary, where it was taught as a subject. It was through the portals of this educational system that the Indian mind made its first acquaintance with the West and it is this educational system that is mainly, if not exclusively, responsible for the modern renaissance

in all walks of Indian life.

One of the most important results of the new education was the birth of a new literature and press in the modern Indian languages. As stated already, the pioneer work in this direction was done by the missionaries. It was they who started the first printing press in India and established the first newspaper. They studied the modern Indian languages, compiled dictionaries, wrote their grammars, and translated the Bible into them. But they never intended to build up a literature in modern Indian languages. Their two main objects were (a) to create aids for the study of these languages by European missionaries, and (b) to translate the Bible and allied literature into them. As soon as both these objectives were realised, they had no further incentive to attempt the creation of a new literature for the people. The officials of the Company and, later on, the Education Departments took up this work and although they came into the field after the missionaries, they did a far greater and more valuable service to the cause. It was under this official patronage that the first attempts to write and publish books of a secular character in modern Indian languages were made. In keeping with the aims of the new educational system, the earliest books published were translations of well-known English books or treatises on subjects like history, algebra, geometry, etc., that were being taught in the new system of schools. Prior to 1854, it was the Committees, Boards, or Councils which were in charge of education or the special *School Book* societies organised for the purpose that prepared and published new books in modern Indian languages and received aid from the Company to do so. After 1855, the work was continued, on a larger scale than before, by Government Book-depots that came to be organised under the Education Departments. A little later, private Indian enterprise came into the field. Some of the men educated in the new system of education felt that books of the type that are found in the English language ought also to be available in modern Indian languages. They, therefore, formed societies for creating such literature in the modern Indian languages or wrote and published books in their individual capacity. They also conducted newspapers with the main object of spreading Western knowledge and bringing about social reforms. As this

non-official agency began to develop, the work of Government Book-depots came to be gradually restricted to the preparation and publication of text-books for schools, and the task of producing a new genuine literature in modern Indian languages and of building up an Indian press was almost exclusively taken up by enthusiastic and nationally minded individuals educated in the new system of secondary schools and colleges. They did their task admirably well, especially in view of the almost complete neglect of the study of these languages in the new educational institutions and by 1902, all the important modern languages of India had evolved a fair amount of new literature and the Indian press had developed to a fairly high degree of efficiency.

In social and religious matters also, the new education was creating valuable changes. The early hopes that Indians educated in Western knowledge would espouse Christianity in large numbers were soon proved to be wrong; but the new education did lead to the creation of a movement whose object was to reform Indian society. This was particularly noticeable within the Hindu fold because it was the Hindu society that needed most reform and it was the Hindus that came most largely under the influence of the new education. Within the Hindu community, therefore, we find movements for the liquidation of the caste-system; for the acceptance of widow-remarriage and divorce among the higher castes; for raising the ages of marriage and consent; for the removal of dietary restrictions based on caste; for the abolition of untouchability; and for the amelioration of the economic condition of the Harijans. Moreover, there also arose strong movements for religious reform. Among these, reference has already been made to the work of Raja Ram Mohan Roy, and the founding of the Brahmo Samaj. Far more powerful than this was the movement of the Arya Samaj founded by Swami Dayanand Saraswati. The object of this reform was to rejuvenate the Hindu society on the pattern of the Vedic Aryan culture. There was to be no caste-system and all persons belonging to the new sect were to be elevated to the status of Aryans and were to enjoy equal social and religious privileges. This was a movement which aimed at welding the whole of the Hindu society into a powerful and homogeneous mass and

spread largely in the Punjab and U.P. The Ramakrishna Mission, started in Bengal in 1897 under the leadership of Swami Vivekanand, was another reformist movement of great importance. A detailed study of the socio-religious history of this period is obviously beyond the scope of this book; but what has already been said above is enough to indicate the various waves of social and religious reform that arose out of the new system of education.

Even greater was the effect of the new education on the *political life* of the country. In the early years of the new educational system, the attention of educated individuals was drawn most to social reforms. This was partly because social work was really urgent and partly because it did not encounter any opposition from Government. A large majority of the educated men of this period were servants of Government and they found it more convenient to undertake programmes of social reform than to organise political agitation as such. Social and religious reform, therefore, became the principal channel through which the educated intelligentsia tried to serve the country. But very soon, a band of younger men began to come up who felt that mere social and religious work can never solve the problems before the country and that the only way to bring about a regeneration of India was through a political control of Government. This rising group of men could not see eye-to-eye with several official policies and openly criticised them in no equivocal manner. They had no illusions about the blessings of British Rule and although they admitted the several good things that Britain had done for India, they could not ignore the growing poverty of the people and the economic exploitation of their country under British imperialism. They, therefore, raised a voice of protest against the *superior airs* or *chill courtesies of reserve* which Englishmen assumed in their dealings with Indians; the exclusive British monopoly of all higher posts under Government; the economic drain on the country; the growing poverty among the people; the failure to develop the industrial resources of the nation; the slow development of education—primary and higher; and such other ills. It is out of these protests that a political agitation slowly grew up in course of time and led to the establishment of the Indian National Congress in 1885.

It is often asserted that this political agitation was a direct and exclusive result of the modern system of education. This is going a bit too far and ignoring the laws of history. No nation can continue to govern another for a long time without creating opposition and discontent. Hence, even if the British people had made no attempt to educate Indians, a political agitation against British Rule was bound to start, sooner or later. But having stressed the view that the political agitation in India could have originated even in the absence of the new system of education, it cannot be gainsaid that this agitation was strengthened materially by the new education. Men and women who had read English history could not but be inspired by the ideals of democracy and self-rule and they began to plead that India was for Indians and that *good* government, even assuming that it did exist, was no substitute for self-government. It was the new system of education, therefore, that gave educated Indians an insight into Western political life, created or strengthened their love of liberty and showed them the way in which to organise a fight against their foreign rulers.

Another great achievement of this period was *the change brought about in the Western attitude to Eastern religion, philosophy and literature*. Prior to 1813, the average Englishman believed, on the basis of missionary propaganda, that all Eastern religions were false and that all literatures in the Eastern classical languages were utterly useless—an attitude that is so typically expressed by Charles Grant. More or less the same view continued to be held till 1854 as the Minutes of Macaulay, Bentinck and Auckland will show. It is true that there was a rival view in the field held by such eminent persons as Warren Hastings, Minto, Wilson, Prinsep and other orientalist who believed that Eastern philosophy, religion and literature deserved a careful study. But they were a small minority. Macaulay would have eliminated them altogether; but could not. Auckland continued them no sufferance in a limited field, but at least left them in peace; and the Despatch of 1854 grudgingly admitted that some advantages do spring from a study of Eastern classical languages. It admitted, for instance, that a study of these languages did have a place on historical, antiquarian or legal grounds. But all the same, it still believed that "the system of science and philosophy which forms the

learning of the East abounds with grave errors". This hostile attitude, however, began to give way soon after 1854.

An epoch-making event in the new movement was the publication, in 1801-2, of a French translation of the *Upanishads*. This had been prepared by a French scholar, A. Duperron, from a Persian translation of the *Upanishads* prepared by Prince Dara Shikoh, the eldest brother of Aurangzeb. It fell into the hands of Schopenhauer, the great German philosopher, who was deeply stirred by it and with him begins the influence of Eastern philosophy on the West—a movement which gathered strength with the passage of years and which has, if anything, become stronger at present than ever in the past. Above this very time another great Sanskrit scholar, Sri William Jones, was translating Sanskrit works into English and popularising them. His translation of Kalidas's *Shakuntala* was a masterpiece of literary art. He also laid the foundation of comparative philology. But by far the greatest service in popularising the Eastern classical languages was done by the greatest of all Orientalists of the nineteenth century, Max Müller. His great work was the translation of the *Vedas*—a task at which he laboured for thirty years in spite of poverty and neglect. The work of these and other western scholars who followed them was soon greatly strengthened by the newly created Indian universities. Although these bodies neglected the modern Indian languages they gave every encouragement to the classical ones. Consequently, a critical and scientific study of the classical languages became a distinct feature of collegiate in the Victorian Era. It led to a better appreciation of ancient culture, removed the misconceptions about ancient history and religion which had been made common in the earlier period by ignorant official or missionaries, and created an Indian band of Oriental scholars among whom may be mentioned the names of Dr. R. G. Bhandarkar, Dr. Rajendralal Mitra, K. T. Telang and others. These pioneers carried the torch still further and, if English education was trying to interpret the West to the East, these orientalists were trying to interpret the East, not only to the West, but to the East itself in a light and context that had not been known before. It is, therefore, the work of these oriental scholars in Indian universities that was gradually bringing about a *synthesis* of Eastern and Western cultures. The

orthodox Hindu or Muslim who refused to learn anything of the West was no longer in the forefront; in the same way, the missionary who wanted to substitute Eastern culture by the Western was also relegated to a subordinate position. And the new Indian Universities which taught English and the classical languages together were creating a generation in whom the synthesis of both the cultures had begun to take place. The emphasis was still on the West no doubt; but the East had no longer to wait outside as an *untouchable*—she was admitted straight into the innermost shrine.

With the achievement of this synthesis, some of the evils of the new education began to disappear. In the early years of the new education, the attempt to westernise the content dominated exclusively. Consequently, the students were generally unable to digest the new exotic culture and showed signs of a deep cultural unsettling. They blindly imitated Englishmen in dress, manners, and outward social behaviour; they drank wine and ate beef rather proudly in the belief that they were copying Western virtues; they thought it beneath their dignity to talk or write in an Indian language and used English as often as possible; and most of all, they developed a contempt for all Eastern or ancient ideas. Some of them became converts to Christianity; several more became atheists or agnostics; and some joined the Brahmo or Prarthana Samajes. It was this erratic behaviour of the early educated youths that frightened many an orthodox parent and hindered the progress of the new system of education. But as the emphasis on westernisation decreased, as Eastern culture came to be better appreciated, and as a synthesis of the two cultures began to be worked out to an ever-increasing extent, the cultural disturbances of the new educational system became less and less pronounced. It is true that the new education freed the Indian mind from the thralldom of old-world ideas; but it now began to be more evident that all that is new is not good, nor all that is old is bad. Discrimination began to be exercised and while absorbing several new ideas from the West, an attempt began to be made to preserve all that is good in the East as well. It is out of this synthesis that the new leadership in Indian national life was born in this period—a leadership included such great names as those of Pandit Ishwarchandra Vidyasagar, Keshub

Chandra Sen, Swami Vivekananda, Justice M. G. Ranade, Pandit Madan Mohan Malaviya, Dadabhai Naoroji, Sir Syed Ahmed Khan and others.

Turning to the other side of the shield, we find that the main defects of this new education were two: In the first place, it was not intended to contribute and did not contribute to the economic and industrial development of India. Secondly, it was restricted to a small percentage of the population only. The paucity of funds and the adoption of English as the medium of instruction implied that this education could never be given to the masses. It, therefore, led to the creation of a new class or small intelligentsia, that did not have much in common with the masses. Moreover, this new class was urban in character, partly because the secondary schools and colleges were all located in towns and partly because the nature of their subsequent employment compelled most educated men to live in towns only. Thirdly, it consisted mostly of persons drawn from the upper castes or the well-to-do classes of society. In other words, the new system of education led to the division of the Indian society into two distinct groups—a small minority of highly educated men and women, an educated aristocracy which was distinctly urban and upper-class in character, and a large majority of almost illiterate people who lived in rural areas and belonged to the lower castes. It is out of this schism that most of the evils of modern Indian education arose and, unfortunately, the schism still remains unbridged.

Primary Education (1854-1902): The history of primary education during this period can be conveniently studied under four heads: (a) the Despatch of 1859, (b) events of the period 1859-82, (c) recommendations of the Indian Education Commission (1882-83) and (d) events of the period 1882-1902.

Despatch of 1859: The Despatch of 1854 had recommended, (a) that the indigenous schools should be incorporated in the official system of education, (b) that larger amounts should be spent on primary education, and (c) that a system of grants-in-aid should be evolved for private primary schools on which alone should Government mainly rely for the spread of education among the masses. But as early as 1859, another Despatch reversed these

orders, directed that local rates should be levied for educational purposes, and observed that the Department should rely mainly on Government schools for the spread of mass education. It said:

On the whole, Her Majesty's Government can entertain little doubt that *the grant-in-aid system, as hitherto in force, is unsuited to the supply of Vernacular Education to the masses of the population; and it appears to them, so far as they have been able to form an opinion, that the means of elementary education should be provided by the direct instrumentality of the officers of Government*, according to some one of the plans in operation in Bengal and the North-Western Provinces, or by such modification of those schemes as may commend itself to the several local Governments as best suited to the circumstances of different localities. . . .

As regards the source from which the funds for Elementary Education should be obtained, it has been on different occasions proposed by officers connected with Education that, in order to avoid the difficulties experienced in obtaining voluntary local support, an Education Rate should be imposed, from which the cost of all schools throughout the country should be defrayed. And other officers who have considered India to be as yet unprepared for such a measure, have regarded other arrangements as merely temporary and palliative, and the levy of a compulsory rate as the only really effective step to be taken for permanently supplying the deficiency.¹

Perhaps the explanation of these recommendations of the Despatches of 1854 and 1859 which generally contradict each other on the subject of elementary education, and the subsequent controversies that raged round them till about 1870, may be traced to the contemporary controversies in England. At this time, elementary education in England was mostly provided by denominational schools supported, to a certain extent, by Parliamentary grants. But opinion was keenly divided regarding the future of elementary education. One section held the view that voluntary effort—which meant mostly the denominational schools—was the best agency for the spread of elementary education, and that

¹Paras. 50-52.